ERA 21

The Vietnam War

1954 – 1975

Escalation · a guerrilla war · a divided home front · withdrawal

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did the United States get drawn into Vietnam—and why couldn't it win?

KEY TERMS

The domino theory · the Gulf of Tonkin · the Tet Offensive · Vietnamization · the fall of Saigon

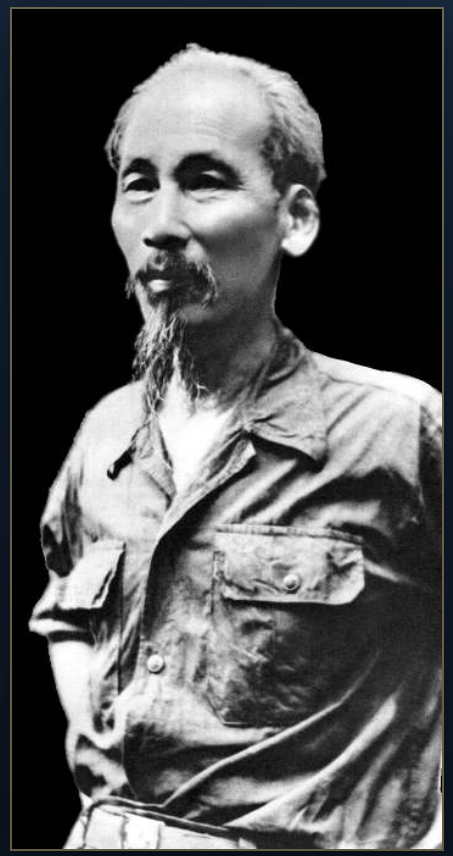
ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 8.8 · AMSCO Ch. 8.8

CONTAINMENT'S LONGEST WAR

Into the Quagmire

The Roots of the War



- Communist **Ho Chi Minh** led Vietnam's fight for independence.
- Fearing the **domino theory**, the U.S. backed South Vietnam.
- After the French defeat, America stepped in to **contain** communism.

Growing Involvement

- Eisenhower and Kennedy sent aid and military '**advisors**.'
- The **Viet Cong** waged a communist insurgency in the South.
- The U.S. commitment deepened, step by step.



Escalation: The Gulf of Tonkin



"All the News That's Fit to Print"

The New York Times.

LATE CITY EDITION

VOL. CXIII—No. 38,910. NEW YORK, WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 5, 1964. TEN CENTS

U.S. PLANES ATTACK NORTH VIETNAM BASES; PRESIDENT ORDERS 'LIMITED' RETALIATION AFTER COMMUNISTS' PT BOATS RENEW RAIDS

F. B. I. Finds 3 Bodies Believed to Be Rights Workers'

GRAVES AT A DAM

Discovery Is Made in New Earth Mound in Mississippi

Scattered Violence Keeps Jersey City Tense 3d Night

400 Policemen Confine Most of Rioters to 2 Sections—Crowds Watch in Streets Despite Danger

REDS DRIVEN OFF

Two Torpedo Vessels Believed Sunk in Gulf of Tonkin

2 CARRIERS USED

McNamara Reports on Aerial Strikes and Reinforcements

FORCES ENLARGED

Stevenson to Appeal for Action by U.N. on 'Open Aggression'

- In 1964, a reported attack on U.S. ships led to the **Gulf of Tonkin** Resolution.
- It gave **Johnson** a blank check to wage war.
- By 1968, over 500,000 U.S. troops were fighting in Vietnam—**escalation**.

A Guerrilla War

- U.S. troops fought an elusive enemy in jungles and villages—**guerrilla warfare**.
- '**Search and destroy**' missions and **napalm** caused heavy civilian casualties.
- It was the first '**television war**'—broadcast into American living rooms.



SECTION

A Nation Divided

The Antiwar Movement



- As casualties mounted, a powerful **antiwar movement** arose.
- The **draft** fueled campus protests across the country.
- Americans split into '**hawks**' (pro-war) and '**doves**' (antiwar).

1968: The Tet Offensive

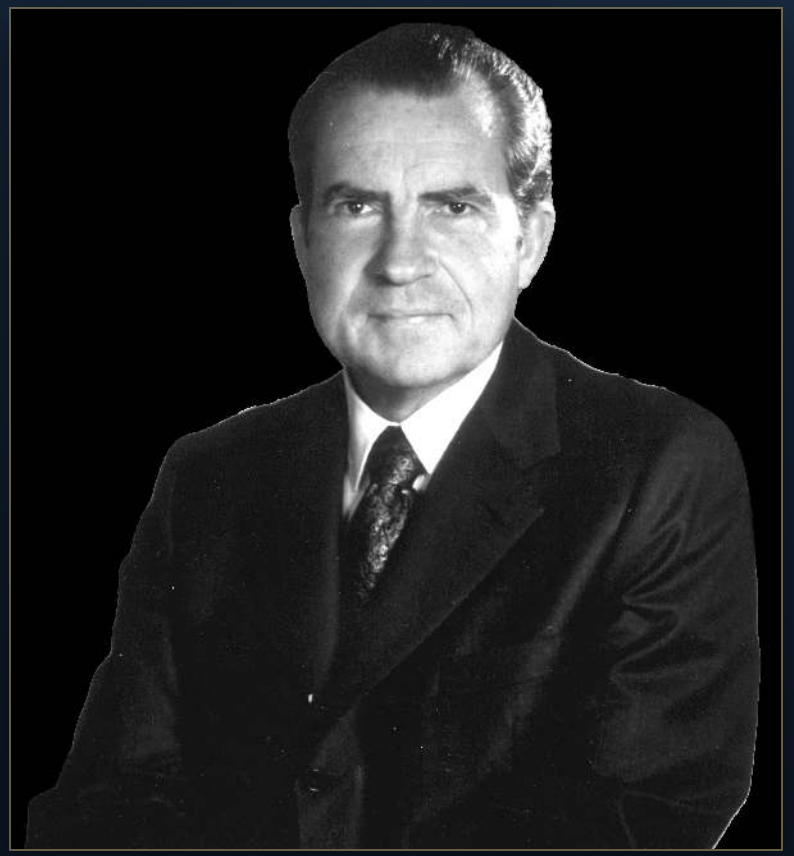
- In early 1968, the **Viet Cong** launched the massive **Tet Offensive**.
- Though a military defeat for the communists, it shocked the American public.
- The **credibility gap** widened—many concluded the war could not be won.



SECTION

The Long Withdrawal

Nixon & the End of the War



- **Nixon** pursued '**Vietnamization**'—turning the fighting over to South Vietnam.
- The **Paris Peace Accords** (1973) ended U.S. involvement.
- In 1975, Saigon fell to the communists; the **War Powers Act** aimed to prevent another Vietnam.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Vietnam War

1. The **domino theory** and **containment** drew the U.S. into Vietnam; the **Gulf of Tonkin** opened the door to **escalation**.

2. A brutal **guerrilla war** and the **Tet Offensive** turned public opinion and widened the **credibility gap**.

3. **Nixon's Vietnamization** led to withdrawal and the **fall of Saigon**—leaving deep scars on American trust in government.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Vietnam War

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how the **domino theory** and **containment** drew the U.S. deeper into Vietnam.

CONTEXTUALIZATION

How did the **Tet Offensive** change American opinion about the war?

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did Vietnam reshape Americans' trust in their **government**?

Up next — **Class 60: A Nation in Turmoil** (the counterculture, feminism & rights movements)